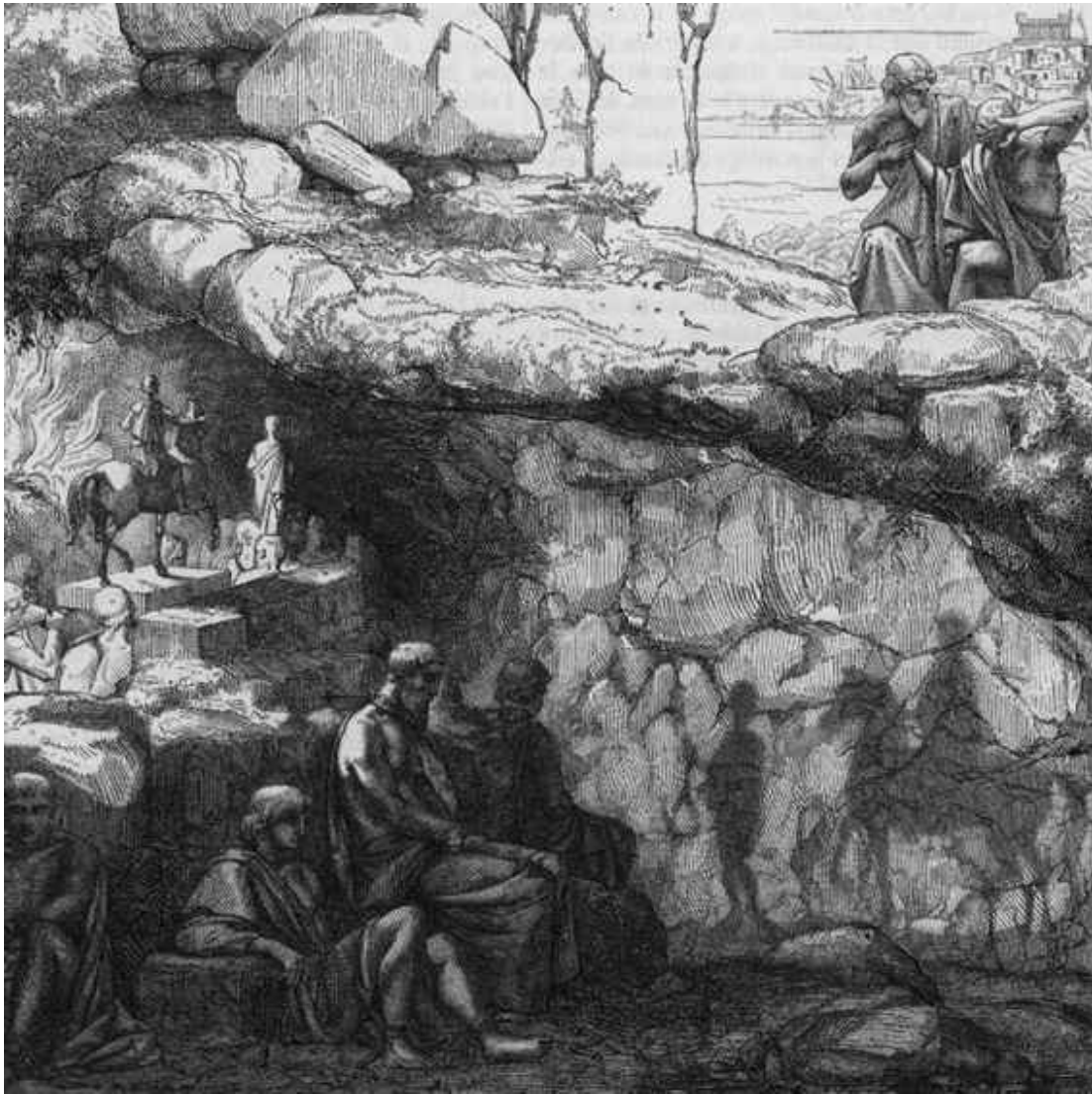


Plato's cave



To illustrate his theory of Forms (see [Plato's theory of Forms](#)), Plato asked his students to imagine a cave, deep enough underground that no daylight reaches it, holding prisoners who have been chained all their lives so that all they can see is its back wall. Behind them is another wall, and beyond this a fire. People along the top of this wall, in front of the first, carry objects on their heads so that the shadows of these things are cast on the wall in front of the prisoners.

As this is all they ever see, Plato argued, the prisoners would assume that these shadows are the only reality, but if they could free themselves, they would discover they were mere shadows of reality. They would also find the light dazzling at first, and if they could make their way to the world outside the cave, would be temporarily blinded by the sunlight. If they returned to the cave, however, they would be unable to see because of the darkness. So it is with the illusory nature of our perception of the world compared to the world of Forms.